

A Safe Path to Producer-Direct Interstate Meat Commerce

Decision brief on producer access, inspection, processing capacity, and interstate commerce

Prepared by Cutline Compliance

Independent public-source policy analysis | Updated September 24, 2026

THE POLICY QUESTION

Ranchers already can sell producer-owned inspected meat to the public and across state lines. The September 4, 2026 executive order makes expansion of producer processing and interstate market access an active implementation question. The real policy issue is how to expand lawful processing pathways without weakening public-health outcomes or disrupting scale-dependent functions the broader meat system still needs.

Key judgments

- Diversification is a stronger objective than replacement. More regional and producer-controlled inspected capacity can improve competition and resilience while large plants continue serving scale-dependent functions.
- Large packers remain important system infrastructure for high-throughput slaughter/fabrication, standardized inputs for further processors, co-product markets, and large-volume export programs.
- Permission does not create capacity. Capital, skilled labor, refrigeration, wastewater/rendering, inspection access, throughput, committed buyers, and byproduct economics determine whether new plants are viable.
- Food-safety outcomes should remain nonnegotiable. Any new commercial producer-direct pathway should preserve ante/post-mortem inspection and protections equivalent to applicable Federal public-health outcomes.

What current law already allows

- Federal inspection: the broadest existing commercial pathway. A producer may retain ownership, use an official establishment, brand the product, and sell inspected-and-passed meat interstate subject to applicable requirements.
- Cooperative Interstate Shipment (CIS): selected small State-inspected plants in participating State MPI programs may ship interstate under same-as-Federal requirements and FSIS oversight. Ordinary State MPI operates under an at-least-equal standard.
- Talmadge-Aiken (TA): approved State personnel perform Federal inspection functions at establishments with a Federal grant. TA is a supervised Federal staffing arrangement, not State MPI or CIS (FSIS Directive 5720.4).

Where expansion hits the legal wall

Barrier	Current rule	Decision implication
Custom exemption	21 U.S.C. § 623 / 9 C.F.R. § 303.1: owner-use product; "Not for Sale."	Commercializing ordinary custom meat requires Congress to alter the statutory framework or create a new commercial lane.
Ordinary State MPI	State MPI programs must provide inspection that is at least equal to the Federal program, but ordinary State-inspected product is principally intrastate.	Interstate expansion requires CIS or new statutory authority, such as a DIRECT-style lane.
Federal-only States	19 States do not operate active State MPI programs as of September 18, 2026.	CIS alone cannot cover these States. Federal inspection is available; TA may staff it where FSIS and a State establish a viable agreement. A new Federal lane needs Congress.

Policy options and trade-offs

Policy action	Decision value	Primary constraint / trade-off
1. Expand CIS support; assess TA staffing	Supports eligible State-inspected CIS plants and may improve Federal inspection delivery where a TA agreement is viable.	CIS requires qualifying State MPI and plant selection. TA requires approved personnel, Federal supervision, onsite and data reviews, and annual agreement assessment; it does not create CIS eligibility.
2. Enact limited State-inspected interstate DTC authority	A DIRECT-style lane could allow qualifying State-inspected product to reach household consumers interstate while retaining inspection, records, recall capability, and clear identification.	Requires Congress; does not solve Federal-only States; opponents question whether State-inspected interstate sales sufficiently preserve Federal inspection norms.
3. Create a proposed Federal Direct Producer Inspection (DPI) lane	Would address Federal-only States and producer-owned/cooperative/mobile/regional operations that cannot access CIS while preserving commercial inspection.	Requires statutory authority and rulemaking; is untested; must solve inspector availability, facility standards, economics, traceability, and enforcement.
4. Finance viable capacity and protect system functions	Targets the real capital, workforce, cold-chain, wastewater, throughput, and buyer constraints while preserving further-processing, co-product, and export capacity.	Financing cannot rescue weak business models and does not itself remove statutory market-access barriers.

Implementation guardrails

- Ante-mortem and post-mortem inspection.
- Sanitation, sanitary dressing, hazard-control protections at least equivalent to applicable Federal public-health outcomes, SRM controls, and applicable humane-handling requirements.
- Truthful labeling and a legally authorized inspection legend.
- Electronic lot traceability linking producer, establishment, slaughter/processing lot, and customer shipment, with written recall capability.
- Domestic-first implementation; no special export status unless FSIS and importing-country requirements are satisfied.

NEBRASKA IS THE HARD TEST

Nebraska has no active State MPI program: plants seeking commercial interstate sales use Federal inspection, while ordinary custom-exempt product is not for sale. CIS would require State MPI buildout and a CIS agreement. TA staffing could be explored only if FSIS and Nebraska establish a workable Federal inspection agreement; a proposed new Federal lane requires Congress.

Recommended sequence

1. Use current authority first: support CIS in qualifying MPI States; assess TA staffing only where FSIS and a State can meet Directive 5720.4; preserve Federal inspection controls.
2. Use legislation where the FMIA creates the wall: authorize a limited inspected interstate DTC lane and evaluate a Federal DPI pathway for Federal-only States.
3. Tie access reform to viable capacity and system protection: workforce, infrastructure, traceability, downstream further-processing inputs, co-products, cold chain, and export eligibility.

CUTLINE POLICY PRINCIPLE: **Deregulate unnecessary market-access barriers - not the public-health outcome.**

Selected evidence base: White House executive order (Sept. 4, 2026); USDA New Mexico MPI approval (Sept. 18, 2026); 7 U.S.C. § 1633; 21 U.S.C. §§ 623, 661, 683; 9 C.F.R. §§ 303.1, 321.2 and Part 332; 76 Fed. Reg. 24714 (2011); FSIS Directives 5720.4, 5740.1 and 8160.1; USDA ERS (MacDonald, 2024); Saitone et al. (2024). Full references and methodology appear in the complete report.

Full analysis: A Safe Path to Producer-Direct Interstate Meat Commerce, full report (inspection-authority update, September 24, 2026).

<https://cutlinecompliance.com/intelligence/producer-direct-interstate-meat-commerce>

Independent educational and policy analysis based exclusively on publicly available information. This material does not represent the views, findings, policy, or official position of USDA, FSIS, or any other government agency. DPI is a Cutline-created policy recommendation, not an existing FSIS program.